

Stratus' new computer line aimed at rival Digital

By Ronald Rosenberg
Globe Staff

Stratus Computer Inc. is taking aim at No. 1 rival Tandem Computer, as well as Digital Equipment Corp., with the introduction this morning of a new line of fault-tolerant computers.

Of Stratus' four new models, the most powerful can handle 50 transactions per second, compared with Tandem's 40 transactions and about 15 transactions per second for the VAX 8650, one of Digital's larger machines, according to Stratus. The new line is priced between \$261,000 and \$1 million.

"We have tripled the high end of our computer performance and reduced the cost per transaction by half," William E. Foster, president and co-founder of the Marlborough-based computer company, said last week.

Both Stratus and Tandem are the leading suppliers of on-line transaction processing systems — computer systems designed to provide a steady stream of information without a computer failure. Primary customers are banks, which use them to provide information for automatic-teller machines, Wall Street brokerage and financial service organizations, transportation and manufacturing companies.

To achieve such fault-tolerance, Stratus relies on redundant hardware, such as two central-processing units, dual memory and disc sys-



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tems. Tandem achieves the same results largely through software.

Digital, which does not claim to be fault-tolerant, gains high reliability of its computers by clustering them for such customers as banks and financial-service firms.

"Increasingly Digital is becoming more of a factor and over time we expect them to be our biggest competitor," said Foster.

The new Stratus line, which will be available in 90 days, will also be marketed by International Business Machines Corp., which has been selling current Stratus machines. IBM sales accounted for 14.5 percent of Stratus' \$124 million in revenues last year.